

SECRET

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BDI. At one point, said Polindexter (getting slightly ahead of his chronology), he asked Soviet Foreign Minister Eduard Shevardnadze "What do you fear from the Strategic Defense Initiative?" According to the Admiral, the Soviet "avoided answering the question."

The other areas of conflict had to do with regional issues, human rights, particularly Jewish immigration, bilateral issues. Polindexter noted that earlier ~~in the talks~~ the Soviet Union had ~~not~~ had "such impact on the low numbers of immigration."

Mikhail Gorbachev had received the U. S. positions (above) and in turn given the Americans his. Saturday ~~evening~~ night the working groups were named. One ~~group~~ on arms control and the other on human rights etc. The arms group worked 10 1/2 hours -- through the entire night. The other group worked ~~approximately~~ 5 1/2 hours. The latter group agreed on positions for a work plan for the next several months that would provide a continuing dialogue on regional, bilateral, immigration and other human rights issues.

The arms issues were, of course, the sticky ones. Saturday night the ~~working arms~~ group reached agreement on a "way of handling short-range INF problem." According to the Admiral, the two sides agreed to freeze the short-range INF level at the current USSR level and continue negotiations once the long-range INF issue was settled. The long-range INF agreement ~~emerged~~ emerged from a proposal that each side accept 100 missiles ~~in Europe~~, 100 in Asia for the Soviets, and 100 in the U. S. for the Americans. The bargaining went on through Saturday night and before it was done the Soviets had agreed ~~to~~ to a zero-zero formula for Europe, but they wanted to delay on the Asian cut back. The U. S. team balked on that. By Sunday, however, the Soviets had agreed to come down to ~~approximately~~ ~~about~~ a hundred missiles ~~each~~ for each side, theirs in ~~Europe~~ ~~and~~ and ours in the United States. Polindexter felt that agreement was significant for the Soviets, representing a 100 percent reduction in Europe, 80 percent in Asia, in all a reduction from 1700 ~~war~~ war heads to 100. "We agreed ~~to~~ to that," declared the Admiral.

Though all of us in this discussion referred to "negotiations," Polindexter said the talks ~~always~~ were in the framework of preparing instructions for the foreign ministers for the summit in Washington, ~~so that they might draft proposals that would lead to a treaty.~~ ~~This~~ All of the above, as indeed, all of what follows, was "held hostage" to BDI, said Polindexter. ~~They cannot START.~~

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By Saturday night, by the Admiral's account, both sides had agreed on 1,600 strategic delivery nuclear vehicles. (This was in the talks on START) They also had ~~agreed~~ agreed on 6,000 nuclear warheads. The Soviets, said Polindexter, were resisting the negotiations of sub limits but they thought that could be done in Geneva. One of the significant changes ~~in~~ in the Soviet position was that they agreed that bombers with gravity bombs and short-range attack ~~missiles~~ ~~constituted~~ ~~one~~ ~~entry~~ vehicle. "That meant that we had solved the problem on how to ~~start~~," said the Admiral. The understanding covered ICBMs, SSBNs,

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The Soviet Working group, was unusual, continued the Security Aide, because the head of it was Sergei Akhmedov, ~~chief~~ chief of staff and deputy defense minister. The head of the American group was veteran arms negotiator Paul Nitze. Almost immediately Saturday night, the problems with SUI emerged. The Soviets were not willing to ... move the START understanding ahead unless we agreed not to withdraw from the ABM treaty for 10 years. They also wanted, said the Admiral, to make the ABM treaty more restrictive on the issues of the meaning of research and development and testing. The Soviet intention to link SDI and START was, thus, plain. And then that position of the Soviet's grew into linkage with ~~transferring~~ INF, also.

^ AND NUCLEAR TESTING

7. On nuclear testing, the working arms group agreed ~~that the~~ ~~begin~~ negotiations on further limitations of nuclear testing. The first item on the agenda was to be verification. The U.S. position was to have an agreement that would provide further limitations on testing but ~~has~~ worked out ~~in~~ in conjunction with the agreement to reduce offensive forces. Ultimately, said the Admiral, the idea was to have a comprehensive test ban ~~in~~ treaty at that point where we no longer had to rely on nuclear weapons for strategic deterrence.

Sunday was the crucial day. Reagan laid out the American proposal in the morning meeting which ran over the limit by an hour or so. The President, said Poindexter, ran into the same linkage with Gorbachev, though, again, there was remarkable agreement in other areas like INF. After the Hagan-Corb meeting ended, Reagan huddled with Shultz and Poindexter and refined the proposal. They agreed to abide by the ABM treaty for 5 years and if the Soviets ~~reduced~~ reduced their missiles at the agreed upon rate and continued to do so in the second five years, the U. S. would continue compliance for the ~~next~~ full 10 years. "By 1996," said Poindexter, "both sides would have eliminated all their ballistic missiles. At the end of ~~15~~ 10 years both sides would feel free to deploy ~~any~~ any SDI system unless otherwise agreed upon by both parties."

Back at the table, the Soviets still balked. The General Secretary would not yield on the SDF ~~point~~. "He wanted an agreement," declared the Admirer, "restricting research, development and testing ~~of a space based system~~ of a space based system to the laboratory. The President felt this was essentially killing the SDF program. He was not willing to ~~accept~~ accept this restriction."

~~It was frankly a little busy here on the radio earlier in the morning~~
~~any would advise further speaking. It appears that after the American proposal~~
~~proposal was made in the evening by Reagan, the Soviets came back with~~
~~several modifications. The Americans then came up with a counter-~~
~~counter proposal which moved the position back toward the first.~~
~~Then, Reagan said, "I think we have reached a point where we should say, 'This is going~~

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In his own final offer."

The meeting did end in bitterness, insisted Poindexter. "There was a sadness on our part." He did not question the sincerity of the Soviets, he said, but "the reason we are so insistent that we eventually have a defensive system is that, based on the history of our relationship with the Soviet Union, we are not absolutely so confident that the reductions proposed will actually be carried out. The defense system is an insurance policy. Our national security and that of most of the free world depends on confidence with such a START Treaty. It is only reasonable and prudent that both sides deploy defensive systems if they so desire. We fail to see that a defensive system against ballistic missiles could possibly constitute a threat. We do not understand what the Soviets fear in a defensive system."

At this point our source went on background. He speculated that perhaps the Soviets feared that a defensive system might be used against weapons on the ground, although the Soviet scientists have told Americans they are not worried about that. Maybe, suggests our source, Gorbachev has a political problem, being so far out on a limb now he cannot yield on SDI. Or maybe he cannot really make reductions called for in these negotiations. The war rhetoric may have gotten put ahead of reality, says our man. ~~End~~

Back on the record. Asked about the problems of verification, The Admiral said the asymmetry of our societies made it very difficult for us to detect Soviet weapons development. In the U.S., of course, the press would poke and prod, a President would insist on living up to arms agreements and Congress could constantly look over his shoulder. He doesn't have the same checks on them.

Poindexter said that the President understood the "historic proportions" of this meeting and the action he had taken, ~~and~~ "of what was on the table."

"We're not going to give up," he declared. "We are going to find some way to preserve SDI and still have reductions in nuclear weapons. Both sides need to reflect on what happened for a few days." There was very little seriousness on either side, continued Poindexter, which is reason for some hope. But there is no prospect now of any near term meeting.

Hugh Sidey, Time

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